

Returning to a damaged home

RECOVERY / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Do not enter a building with gas smell, floodwater, unstable walls, damaged wiring or other serious hazards. A quiet street or an opened road is not proof that a home is safe. Inspect only from a safe outside position and arrange qualified assessment for structural and utility damage. Keep children and pets away.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check the approach**
01 Avoid debris, unstable trees, wires, floodwater and suspicious remnants after conflict. Do not cross a hazard to inspect a property.
- ☐ **Look from outside**
02 Check for leaning walls, sagging roof, fire, gas smell and water around electrical equipment. Do not enter to locate the source of a hazard.
- ☐ **Keep utilities untouched if unsafe**
03 Do not turn on damaged power, gas or flooded equipment. Qualified personnel must assess these systems; do not test them yourself.
- ☐ **Document only when safe**
04 Photograph visible damage from a safe position and retain receipts. Property records are less urgent than staying out of danger.
- ☐ **Use a temporary safe base**
05 Keep sleeping, food and water in safe accommodation while assessment and cleanup are arranged. Separate clean belongings from contaminated items.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Remain in the safest available temporary shelter if inspection services are not operating. Delayed assessment is not permission to occupy a visibly unsafe home.

Watch for.

Do not remove load-bearing debris, enter a confined space or approach explosive debris. Personal inspection cannot certify structural safety.

People & practical needs.

Keep children, pets and people vulnerable to dust or mold outside the work area. Agree who assesses access, who manages dependents and where the clean sleeping and drinking-water space will be

Next decision.

After qualified clearance, plan protective equipment and safe cleanup for the specific hazard. Flood, fire and conflict damage require different precautions. Verify contractors before paying.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov · Recovering from disaster](#)

[CDC · Flood safety](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/returning-home/>